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Wendell Harrison Part 2

Part 2 was conducted via Zoom on November 17, 2022 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

This meeting is being recorded.

MR: Oh, thanks a lot for telling me that.

WH: Wait a minute, where is my mouse? Okay. I've got it.

MR: Okay.

WH: All right.

MR: So let me just — yes, okay we are rolling here.

WH: Okay.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and I'm pleased to be back with Wendell Harrison for a few follow-up questions. And you're looking good, as you did last time.

WH: Oh thank you. Thank you, thank you. That means a whole lot at my age. I'm still here. Yeah.

MR: I'm fascinated and curious about Sun Ra and I wanted to ask you, you entered that band for however many gigs you did as obviously one of the newcomers and you were sitting next to people like Marshall Allen, who had been there since the get-go. Did you get advice from the band members as well as Sun Ra about how to fit into whatever it is they were doing?

WH: Yes. Yes. I was a young guy at that time. I think I was about 20, 21 years old, and I had just gotten, I had just arrived from Detroit. My first engagement was with Grant Green and I was working around, and we would tour, but on the off weeks I would play with Sun Ra. I was introduced to Sun Ra by a euphonium and trombone player, Kiwami Ziti

MR: What was his name?

WH: Kiwami. K-I-N-I-B-I [misspelled] Ziwati. And we were staying together in the loft on Broadway, 89 E Broadway Street. And all kinds of people would come by and sessions, and we studied, actually we were vegetarians at the time. And so he called Kiwami to come in and play for a few gigs and whatnot, and Sun Ra asked Kiwami did he know of a saxophone player. So Kiwami recommended me, because Pharoah had went with — Pharoah was doing presentations and performances with Sun Ra as well, but he had worked with Trane. John Gilmore had went with Art Blakey at the time. So there was a vacancy. So I made a rehearsal. Sun Ra stayed on Third Street, not too far from Avenue A. And I went over to Sun Ra's house and he was cooking for the band. He was like of like an old grandmother you know, he was cooking for the band and it was like collard greens and black eyed peas and whatnot, real southern cuisine, because you know he's

from Alabama basically, by way of Chicago. So I didn't really eat that much because I was so excited about playing with the group that I'd never played that way before. I'd never played that free style before you know. So when I started playing he told me to forget about changes, just think about the sound and imagery you know. Let your imagination take control.

MR: Were there changes in the tunes that you even could have worried about?

WH: From what I remember it was just notes. And you'd harmonize from your imagination. It could have been anything. You harmonize — you might hear it as a major, somebody might hear it as a minor, you know. But it was about a collective, a collective sound. And what we worried about was the — he was really conscious and constant about the rhythm, because the rhythm, you know he'd play things in 7/4, 7/8, 5/4, sometimes 4/4 you know, but, and he had bass lines that would go with that particular rhythm and we had to be conscious of the bass line and the rhythm and try to when we improvise, improvise off the melody and improvise from the rhythm context. You know, stay with the rhythm. Stay inside that 7/4 or 7/8. Stay inside that groove. It's a groove that you have to stay with you know. So you play these ideas in the context of the groove, and the energy level has to be up. Because a lot of times he would play celeste, like bells on the keyboard. He had synthesizers and whatnot. You know. And that was a big deal back in the 60s, a synthesizer was something else. You know that was the new technology then.

MR: Yeah. Outer space.

WH: Yeah. Space. And they hadn't really figured out how to make a sound acoustically in terms of — now these keyboards, they can sound like a grand piano you know, they've got samples. Samples is the thing that makes them sound a little more authentic. Back in the day they were more sophisticated noise you know or Moog sounds. The Moog, that was common back in those days. Or a sound like a space ship you know like on T.V. [scats]. Lights going off and on.

MR: I may have a misconception about the group and how they operated, but is there enough to see how did those members of that group actually make a living? Were they making enough money to pay rent and eat?

WH: At that time, see Sun Ra, he got there in '58. I got there in 1960. He brought all his members from Chicago, mainly Ronnie Boykins, the bass player; Pat Patrick was the baritone saxophone player; Marshall Allen, alto; John Gilmore, tenor; and was using Clifford Jarvis on the drums and Lex Humphries. He had another drummer, it might have been Phil Grant, I'm not sure, from Chicago. But I worked with him with Lex Humphries you know. And no, all these guys, they were great musicians so that enabled them to work shows. Like Pat Patrick would work Broadway shows and theaters. Like I say, Gilmore had — took a gig with Art Blakey you know. And all these guys was working

the New York scene as well as with Sun Ra. And Sun Ra would say, "Well I'm not going to pay — there's not going to be that much money but you will become famous if you work with me." I said, "Really?" Well he could talk. I mean he was a salesman, constantly selling. I mean he was really, his ideology, he was very astute, very articulate when it came to expressing ideas and whatnot. You know, and telling stories. Sometimes the rehearsal would go on just listening to his stories, to give you a concept.

MR: I don't mean to sound disrespectful at all but did you ever get the notion in your head like man this cat's kind of crazy?

WH: Of course. Everybody did. But his family, I call them the family, the group that came from Chicago, I mean they were really serious about Sun Ra and they really respected him as a leader and as a spiritual advisor. I wasn't there yet. Because like I was telling you I'm a bebop — I have a bebop mentality and everything in my world had changes. Everything in my world had changes and that was my master, the keyboard and the — I worshipped chord changes at that particular time.

MR: That was your spirituality, right?

WH: My spirituality. You know, so he had to wean me off of that foundation. And then I noticed a lot of guys, he was using a lot of musicians but he liked the guys that didn't have that foundation so much. You know he gravitated to those guys because it was less work to re-indoctrinate you know. Same with John Coltrane. John Coltrane liked Pharoah because he hadn't had the bebop foundation so much. Pharoah was like a blues kind of guy from Arkansas. And he was — me and Pharoah, he was a year older than me. He was a year older than I. He was born in '41, I was born in 1942. And we had gotten to, came to New York on the same day. He was coming from San Francisco, Oakland, California and I was coming from Detroit. And I think the first gig we had I think Pharoah was working with Sun Ra and he started working with Sun Ra before I did, and he was working at Café Wha? There's a club called Café Wha? in the Village, and when he wasn't working with Sun Ra he was washing dishes in the place. You know. And you know we were kids trying to find our way. And one time he was asking for his own showcase, his own performance. And the owner gave him a night, I think it was maybe a Monday night or something like that. And Pharoah for his rhythm section he chose the Blue Note all star group: Billy Higgins, and so I said what? And I didn't think much of it at that time but thinking about Pharoah, his perception of himself, he always had a big image of himself and how he wanted to present himself you know. And that's very important, he had that concept of himself that I think is very important in terms of being a leader. And you know they had to pay these guys and it was more than they expected to pay. Pharoah said, "You've got to pay my band." You know. And then at that point he was working with Sun Ra and then around different groups and then John Coltrane, he

was hanging out with John Coltrane. John liked him you know. So he did more and more with John and John started using him on gigs and whatnot, and he started touring and whatnot, the rest is history. Now with Sun Ra I used to make fun of Sun Ra but something that I really took serious when I saw he was recording everything you know. Rehearsals. And he had two record labels. You know he was producing and marketing his music, and his music was in the marketplace. Of course it was like a small niche fan base. But it was a fan base nevertheless that he nurtured. I guess he got started in Chicago. He was nurturing this fan base and he didn't care anything about conforming to the status quo at that time, of the major record companies in terms of being a contracted artist for a major label. He didn't want to do that because he would have to conform and play like a contemporary sound or a homogenized sound, that's the way he would put it.

MR: Homogenized is a good word. Can I ask if you recall on the live gigs you played if he attracted a mostly white audience or a mostly black audience?

WH: Yeah. He what? It was mostly a white, young Bohemian hippie audience. You remember those days? You're probably too young.

MR: No I remember. It wasn't in my spirituality though just yet.

WH: Young hippie or the beatnik crowd. You remember the beatnik crowd? And they would smoke hashish, hashish and LSD at that time was big. LSD, hallucinogenics, they were big at that time. Actually peyote too. Peyote and hashish, those were the drugs of the hippies. But they called themselves elite, you know what I mean, back in those days. I'm talking about the 50s and 60s. But that was his audience. And I mean these guys was like anywhere from 18 to 60 years old. And the places where they performed, like the Café Wha? they recited poetry in those days as well as music. So he would have, a lot of times Sun Ra would have a poet. And Sun Ra would recite poetry as well. Even would sing. You know he would sing. And he was great. He was great. They just loved him. They just really loved him.

MR: I just have this picture of you the next morning after a gig with him meeting someone for coffee and saying, "Man you should have seen what I did last night."

WH: That's right. That's right. I would talk about it. "This guy's crazy, this guy's nuts." But guess what? He turned me on — I played a gig with him at a place called the Baby Grand in Harlem and we had to play a dance, we had to play like Duke Ellington and Fletcher Henderson, we had to play swing and a little bebop. Because he'd play like, he could play like Art Tatum on piano you know. Fletcher — you know he could play stride. Kind of remind you of Monk in a way, Thelonious Monk in a way, where he could play the stride. And that was really where — he was that age, he came out of the swing era. I mean he was born at that particular period in time so he could play like a Duke Ellington or a Fats Waller or you know that real swing. So he knew I could play these tunes, so we went and

played, it was called the Baby Grand Ballroom on 125th Street in Harlem, and we were playing "Satin Doll" and "It Don't Mean a Thing" and some of those older tunes. And he liked the way I played that, when he played changes now. So I got to play tunes and he really liked that. You know I made the gig, really made it happen for him. He was very pleased. So a lot of times he'd call me to play these traditional dances, for social dancing. The people, you know two step foxtrots and all that kind of stuff. Tangos and all that kind of stuff.

MR: Well let me foxtrot you back to Detroit for a moment. I want to talk about Tribe Records and the magazine. And I noticed, this could be a total coincidence, but you started with your partner Tribe Records in 1971 is that correct?

WH: Right.

MR: And back in New York Charles Tolliver and his partner started Strata East in 1971. Is that a coincidence or was it the atmosphere and relationship —

WH: That was a coin — now it's really ironic because I played with Sun Ra with Charles Tolliver too and we played other gigs. I played other gigs with Charles and myself with like Olatunji, like the conga player from Nigeria, we played dances and stuff. We was young so we was playing all kinds of gigs, dance gigs we were playing all kinds of social parties for West Africans and you know we were playing Latin stuff. Then we played bebop as well. But Charles is six months older than me. He was born in March, I'm born in October 1942. So when I came back, I actually came back, I was coming from California and stopped in Detroit on the way back to New York and got trapped by my mother. That's another story. You know she's laying a trap for me you know. My mother was a teacher, she had a master's and whatnot. My father had a Ph.D. and he was teaching at Southern University. But anyway, my mother, I had settled on being a musician you know. I'm paying rent but at that particular time she had quit school and she went into real estate, so she had houses and stuff that she was renting out. And she couldn't understand why I'm in New York paying rent. 'Cause she didn't know anything about the entertainment industry or the music industry, especially jazz you know. She said, "How can you make a living, and you don't even own anything, you don't ever own anything."

[gap 23:16]

It's like a plan

[gap]

this is like old school stuff. I mean people would do this stuff in the early 1800s or old African tribal relationships where the elders would plan your wife or husband.

MR: I missed — there was a drop off in our conversation so I kind of missed what you're describing. Your mother had set up this —

WH: Trap.

MR: Little scenario — a trap.

WH: No, well anyway she wanted me to meet a young lady that she, in her mind was a real credible lady and she thought that we could get married and make a family together, you know have kids and whatnot. Never did happen. But it happened where she was very instrumental in managing and administrating some of my gigs and my career. And when I started working and teaching here in Detroit Phil Ranelin and myself, Phil came from Indianapolis, and we put together a production company where we was producing shows at the art institute, it was a museum, the Detroit Institute of Arts. This was a museum. And we produced concerts every three months you know. And then I started teaching here at the same time, teaching jazz studies at a place called Metro Arts. So we produced these shows. It was a program book that we got together and we had people that was working, at the Harrison Association that was working and selling ads and whatnot and tickets ads in the program guide, it was a program guide and they would sell ads. And the revenue off of that money would actually support the musicians, promotion, and renting of the venues. Very successful at that particular time because people wanted to do things. You know people wanted to, especially the black community was coming together, under Nixon, it was really coming together at that particular time because people were very distraught about the war in Vietnam and the economy. The economy was down at that particular time. People didn't have jobs you know, social unrest. Riots was breaking out everywhere you know. People was restless. So anyway, so people would come together, we had artists, photographers, writers, musicians, we came together and formed an organization that presented concerts and stuff every quarter, and that became a foundation for the magazine, the publication magazine called Tribe. And it was a social, economic issue, as well as politics and art. And it was very successful. Then we took some of that money and put it into a record label called Tribe. That was successful because we had independents, independent distributors that no longer wanted to like distribute company product, like Columbia, Atlantic and the whole thing. And they wanted to have their own economy and distributing what they wanted to distribute. You know sometimes these distributors were actually

[Freeze 28:45]

Columbia would only want you to distribute their product. Case in point, just thinking about this, the people that recorded us were

[gap]

Atlantic Records in the distribution were into sales and selling product to distributors and whatnot and they wanted to record independent artists. So they recorded us you know.

Allen Poke, this was in the suburbs of Detroit out in Fraser, Michigan. So we went into the studio

MR: We're having difficulties here with the connection.

WH: Really?

MR: Yeah, unfortunately you're cutting out a lot.

WH: I'm cutting out? Oh wow.

MR: You're cutting out a lot.

WH: It just started doing that, huh?

MR: Yeah, it's been doing it off and on but it's getting worse, I don't know why.

WH: Can you cut it off and start it up again?

MR: I can, or —

WH: Or stop the recording.

MR: Yeah, I'm going to pause here.

This meeting is being recorded.

MR: Okay. So I started up again. Let me ask you about Tribe. Would bands come to you, groups of musicians, with a finished audio recording and then you would take that and put it out on your label? Or did you work with the musicians from the get-go?

WH: No, well I was working with a cadre of musicians. I was working with Phil Ranelin, which we started a partnership, Tribe Records. The magazine was different. But I needed some help on administrative stuff so I incorporated with Phil and myself as Tribe Records. And then Marcus — I used Marcus Belgrave and Harold McKinney basically was the network. Because we was playing in each other's group. I was playing in Marcus's group, me and Phil was playing in Marcus's group, was playing in Harold's group, you know, and also playing in my group. So we was actually playing in each other's groups. And we knew — although the music was different because we are all composers. We're composers. And so we would write some things and everybody would rehearse it and then we would perform it at different times. You know I would perform in Harold's group, actually I'd been performing with Harold long before I went to New York you know. I was performing with Marcus in Philadelphia and Chester, Pennsylvania. I was performing with him on the road, because he was on the road with other groups and he was writing music. So I knew Marcus's music. Same with Phil. Now we recorded like the first — his album, my album, Phil's album, Harold McKinney's albums we all did as a collective but under each other's name. And then Doug Hammond came in with a tape. He had talked to Charles Tolliver and Charles Tolliver didn't have time at that particular time. I said well I'll give you some time, man, give me the tape and I'll listen to it. And it was good. It was very unique you know. Because it was kind of like free. But kind of like Charles Mingus. It sounded a lot like Charles Mingus with a

groove. And then a guy from Ann Arbor, Ron Brooks submitted some music and David Durrah out of Cleveland submitted some music. So anyway that's how that started, and then we distributed this music by independent distributors that was happening all over America, independent distributors, they wanted to distribute their own product and have their own catalogue as opposed to working for Atlantic Records or a big corporation. This was like an independent revolution as it were, you know, in the 60s. Everybody was rebelling basically from the status quo. Everybody wanted to do their own thing, they had their own economy, we wanted to own our own music, and if we failed at it we had nobody to blame but ourselves. We couldn't blame anybody else, you know. Traditionally speaking if the record didn't, was unsuccessful, you could blame the record company. "Aw they messed me up. The record company messed me up." But this way we were the record company. We were the record company. You know. So we were making sure that there was success, the best way we could.

MR: Yeah. Sort of like saying, "Oh I can't blame my bad saxophone playing on my reed anymore."

WH: Right. Right. So we worked 24 hours — we were so excited I think that the new adventure, the autonomy gave us so much energy, being on our own and to make it happen. So we would lose a lot of sleep thinking about how we were going to do things. Because we didn't know how to do things. We learned, we had a desire to do something but we had to learn the mechanics of it, the infrastructure. We had to learn about that. What makes the — how can I get the music to the marketplace? What makes it successful? Radio stations — we had to talk about radio stations and program directors who deal with program directors and traffic.

MR: I'm guessing between the record label and the magazine that your dining room table was usually covered with papers and business?

WH: Yeah. And everybody — the dining room table was where it's at. It all happened at the dining room table. People would come in from all over the world and we'd sit at the dining room table. You know? And figure stuff out. Have meetings and stuff like that. And I've still got the dining room table, still, it's happening today, 55 years later it's still going on.

MR: I'm sorry, some of this music made its way over to Europe, didn't it?

WH: The first big marketplace we hit was Poland. Poland. The Czech Republic. You know they're the ones that did the big write-up in a magazine talking about the label and talking about the first three different releases and whatnot. Then Germany, then France and Spain and eventually Japan, Australia you know. But we had 15 distributors at that time that was ordering. I was mainly selling myself, because I was excited, excited. Then I had other people that helped me out, but I got it started myself. I would contact the

distributors myself and started packaging these records and taking orders. After we had sent everything out to the radio stations and the magazines and newspapers was writing articles, then I would get on the telephone and talk about how the records was being covered and it's being reviewed and radio stations is playing it, it's in rotation and blah-blah-blah-blah. And then the distributors would say, "Well send me a box." And a box was like 25. And then, next month they want two boxes. You know, of each. I'm talking about each, each, each. A box of mine, a box of Phil's, a box of Marcus's, a box of Harold, Doug. So I'm selling a catalogue and they're picking things off the catalogue. I stumbled into that, you know I stumbled into that.

MR: Would you get to the point, like you're saying okay I've sent three boxes to this distributor and I don't have any monetary return on it. Was that your job also?

WH: Yeah. That was really hard. That was really hard. Because I didn't know — I'm learning, I'm learning, I'm learning. You know. After a while I'd send them a box. If they wanted more they would have to pay upfront. So they was always, always a month behind in payment. They was always behind. They was always behind in payment you know. And I learned that, and some of the guys didn't pay us, we got screwed you know. Because we was small, we was a small company and they knew they could pay it back. Some of the bigger distributors knew that we were small and they paid us if they felt like paying us they'd pay it. But if they didn't feel like it — you know. There was two of them like that, there was two distributors that was like that. You know. But for the most part we was pretty successful. Now it came to the point where these people wanted more records. So we started getting calls about licensing. That was new, license, oh man, license. That means we don't have to press up — we can just sit on the master. Boy, just one master and then press up thousands of records from that one master. You know. So that made it easy for us, myself, because I wouldn't have to press, there's no press costs, you would have — no mailing costs you know. That cut my whole operation, the operation it cut it 75 percent. 75 or so. All we had to do is record and then send the masters out to these major labels in Europe and Japan. But this happened in 1990. 1990. Because we were — instead of sending the masters we would send a master CD, instead of sending the tape. Before that we would have to go in the studio and make a copy, a copy of a master. You never send your original masters, no way, you never send your original masters nowhere. You know. You always maintain that. You make copies and send it out. So at that time Tribe became worldwide, at that time we had like five or six major labels around the world that was distributing and selling our music and marketing our music. Now we're up to fifteen labels around the world.

MR: Well it's been a labor of love and a labor of soul and everything else in between and I admire that, your passion for it. So I'd like to wrap up today with a question about jazz in

society. Now you're describing this intense relationship with local musicians and spreading it worldwide and when I think back to the swing era that jazz and swing had this social dancing aspect and entertainment value. Do you have a thought about jazz in America now? Where does it fit? Does it have a distinctive character in America now?

WH: Yeah, a lot of different jazz styles now as you know. You know I'm 80 years old. My concept comes out of — the genesis of my concept came from the 50s from the bebop era. And when I write, I'm writing — like Oliver Lake —not Oliver Lake but Oliver Nelson — Oliver, Duke Ellington and my head is like that. My head is grounded in that sound although I write all kinds of ways. I've got skills to write all kinds of ways you know. But you know I even learned how to deal with hip hop, I mean techno you know. Because I worked with Carl Craig. Then I started to deal with rap, like I worked with a guy by the name of Proof put out a record called "Grown Folks Shit." That's the rappers. So I'm kind of in terms of me, I'm kind of eclectic with a jazz base, a jazz foundation but I'm eclectic. I deal with African concepts, I deal with Latin concepts, hip hop, but really coming from a jazz perspective. I use all these elements. I even use Sun Ra, but sparingly. I'll go out, but I always come back to my base, my jazz concept. I might go out and play some space music for a couple of minutes but I always come back to who I am. And that's how it's been selling over the years. Jazz today it's just about the college campuses. University campuses today, which is more academic, more academic. Because they don't have the engagements that we had back in the 60s and 70s. We was playing this music every week for a live audience. A live audience every week, we were playing gigs, gigs. So we were playing for the audience and trying to get approval from the audience and at the same time we were trying to sell records too. Because if we went too far out our records wouldn't sell. So we would learn how to play and improvise, including melody and harmonics that everybody could actually digest, the average person could digest. The students now, it seems to me, they're playing for themselves academically and they find out how many notes can you play at once. You know you can play all these notes, how fast can you play? And they have great technique but the story often is not really as prolific as the stories that we told back in the 50s and 60s, this coming from my point of view.

MR: Well said. I like the term, the audience could digest. Something that is acceptable to them and they can get something out of.

WH: Yeah in other words they could take home something. I remember he really played, because he played a nursery rhyme over here. You know? I mean they would relate to something. A melody here that they can pick up on. Not a bunch of scales and chords. Those are just elements of creation. I mean those are just tools of creation. Sort of like using all the crayons in the Crayon box, or all the tools in the toolbox. You know? You

just use — but anyway it all about storytelling. All about storytelling, just like I'm talking now. I'm telling the story and I'm trying to make it as interesting as possible. I'm trying to articulate ideas that people can relate to, instead of using a lot of academic phrases that — the music is over their head.

MR: Over their head.

WH: Yeah. That doesn't work. Of course I had to learn that but it's like something that I've learned just putting this music together I have to do the same thing with interviews and conversation.

MR: Right. Well I'm very glad that all the work you've done over the years in the 70s and beyond seems to be still something you can build on and that it's ongoing. And I'd also like to say that you had one of the best band names ever with Mama's Licking Stick Clarinet Ensemble. I love that.

WH: You know where that came from?

MR: I do not.

WH: My mother, you know every time — when I was eight years old they gave me the clarinet. Eight years old, okay? So for discipline and punishment, if I'd do something wrong instead of giving me a licking, hitting or spanking, "Play your clarinet for an hour today." You know. And I would hate that. It was like punishment to me. Sitting in a room with the clarinet, sitting in the room with this thing for an hour? I mean that was something else. That was the most horrible thing. And then I was made to clean up my room and then do homework.

MR: Well you didn't know that it was going to pay benefits later.

WH: I didn't know that. You know I was just — all I know was I was being punished.

MR: You know Buddy DeFranco call the clarinet an "agony stick."

WH: That's right. I mean to get it to play in tune and keep your hands over the open holes, I mean your fingers over the open holes and stuff like that. And you can't get a lot of volume out of it. So what you play has to be really interesting. It has to be really interesting to keep attention.

MR: This has been interesting for me, and I want to thank you for these great conversations and I hope you never run out of crayons in your crayon box.

WH: I appreciate that, I appreciate that, Monk. You've got the right name, too.

MR: Thank you.

WH: You've got the right name. The priest of jazz, the Monk. I love it.

MR: Thank you very much for your time, Wendell.

WH: Thank you.